

Owen Lopez

Professor Faulconer

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Ethical Conundrums in Software Development

The profession of software engineering carries many consequential decisions that affect not only the organization one works within, but also the broader digital ecosystem and society at large. Software developers design complex systems that can have far-reaching, unexpected consequences for everyone who utilizes them. In Module 1, we considered how technical writing serves as a primary vehicle for professional accountability rather than an isolated administrative task. In both internal documentation and public-facing design, engineers must actively balance corporate growth targets against user well-being and moral responsibility.

Often in software development, employees are tasked with creating dark patterns within their applications. These dark patterns are intentionally designed to trap users within an interface and extract maximum attention, private data, or recurring revenue from them. This manipulation is prevalent across modern social media platforms where algorithmic infinite scrolls capture human attention, or where coercive, persistent push notifications are engineered to manipulate user habits. Addressing this unethical practice, Michael Beilfuss writes, "Do not persuade people to do what is not in their best interest" (sec. 4.8). Implementing dark patterns inflicts tangible negative harm on users' cognitive health, financial security, and personal autonomy. Within my future career, I will inevitably face moments where I must choose whether to comply with building predatory features or actively advocate for transparent, user-centered design alternatives.

Another scenario where I might be encouraged to violate professional ethics involves concealing software vulnerabilities or project setbacks to meet aggressive release deadlines. Beilfuss cautions writers against "misrepresenting facts, or just 'twisting' numbers to favor

your opinion and objectives," noting that when "deadlines to meet, taking shortcuts and stretching the truth become ever more tempting" (sec. 4.8). In software documentation—including pull request reviews, architecture decision records, and deployment release manifests—developers face immense pressure to obscure critical architectural defects or downplay security flaws so that management approves deployment on time. Concealing known flaws misleads non-technical decision-makers and risks deploying compromised systems into production environments. As future professionals, software engineers bear a fundamental obligation to document system limitations truthfully, resist manipulative interface copy, and safeguard the interests of all stakeholders.

Works Cited

Beilfuss, Michael. "Chapter 4: Ethics." *Technical and Professional Writing Genres: A Study in Theory and Practice*, edited by Eric Howerton, Oklahoma State University Libraries / Open Textbook Library, 2020, open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/721. Accessed 30 Sept. 2026.